

## S04-05 - Toward Open Vale

### Player read-aloud

The Custodian closes the crate with both hands. ?We must go to Open Vale. The magic will draw things best left uninvited.?

### Scene summary

The Custodian insists the Keystone must be renewed at Open Vale? Ritual Site.

### Visible choices

- Travel immediately
- Prepare first
- Question the danger

### Player questions

- What detail in Toward Open Vale tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

### Raw source

- Id: S04-05
- Act: Act Four
- Title: Toward Open Vale
- Beats: Threshold / transition Lore reveal
- Image: assets/scenes/S04-05-toward-open-vale.png
- Short: The Custodian insists the Keystone must be renewed at Open Vale? Ritual Site.
- Long: A transition scene. The party moves from mystery/reveal into final heroic defense.
- Read: The Custodian closes the crate with both hands. ?We must go to Open Vale. The magic will draw things best left uninvited.?
- Gm: Skip or montage if time is short.
- Entities: Open Vale? Ritual Site Whitefire Custodian Keystone Asset Marlowe Fairwind Ritual Countdown Short Rest Varian Soto Sealed Keystone Crate
- Choices: Travel immediately Prepare first Question the danger
- Prompt: Party and Custodian prepare to leave Hanging Office with Keystone Asset secured, heading into deeper forest toward ritual clearing; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead yet.
- Source Entities: Open Vale? Ritual Site Whitefire Custodian Keystone Asset
- Beat Codes: threshold-transition lore-reveal
- Slug: S04-05-toward-open-vale
- Act Title: The Hanging Office
- Arc Role: Mentor-custodian truth reveal
- Caption: The final approach turns understanding into preparation.

- Image Alt: Toward Open Vale scene art for The Hanging Office.
- Image Prompt Used: Party and Custodian prepare to leave Hanging Office with Keystone Asset secured, heading into deeper forest toward ritual clearing; no strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead yet. Do not include the Strixwolf Mother, strixwolf pups, wolves, owlbeats, or animal companions unless explicitly requested. No strixwolf, no Bramble Union, no undead. Focus on the Custodian and the Keystone Asset reveal. 4:3 cinematic fantasy concept art, no visible text, no captions, no logos, no UI, no watermark.
- Long Storyboard: A transition scene. The party moves from mystery/reveal into final heroic defense. Run this scene as mentor-custodian truth reveal: The final approach turns understanding into preparation. Keep the camera close to practical choices, visible consequences, and the difference between ordinary people and the infrastructure pressing on them.
- Read Aloud: The Custodian closes the crate with both hands. "We must go to Open Vale. The magic will draw things best left uninvited."
- Gm Notes: Skip or montage if time is short. Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it. Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- Sensory Details: grass bending toward the ward distant thunder without clouds the Keystone growing heavier at every step
- Body Language: The Custodian saves breath for the ritual Varian stops joking when the animals go quiet
- Sample Dialogue: Marlowe Fairwind We deliver it, then we defend what delivery was supposed to mean.
- Checks: Instinct or Knowledge Choose approach and prepare for the ritual site. Standard Place the party well for Act Five. 15 Cleanly resolve: Choose approach and prepare for the ritual site. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to Toward Open Vale. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then systemic truth.
- Choices Consequences: Scout first Gain better opening position. Ward defense improves. Rush directly Begin sooner but with less control. Countdown pressure rises.
- Clues: Open Vale pull The site is near. The ward has a memory of its own. The Keystone physically wants the ritual site.
- Loot: Approach advantage One preparation detail each player names Whitefire Custodian's Ward-Charms: A small hand-carved wooden ratcoon mid-scamp has been thumb-worn smooth for luck. It is warm, and the forest feels a little kinder while you hold it.
- Payoff Flags: Ward Stability Track
- Filters: act-four choice gm-only lore-reveal the-hanging-office threshold-- transition ward-stability-track npc manufactured-threat guaranteed-earned

- Index: 17
- Player Questions: What detail in Toward Open Vale tells you the official story is incomplete? Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it? What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?
- Relationship Prompts: Which PC quietly checks on someone else here? Who disagrees about the right thing to do without breaking trust?
- Ownership Prompt: Name one detail in Toward Open Vale that belongs to your character's point of view.
- Reveal Hooks: Loreborne or Knowledge-focused PCs can read the institutional layer. Wildborne/community-focused PCs can read local custom and ecological stress. Martial/security-focused PCs can read threat posture and custody logic. Magic-focused PCs can feel ward tone, soul-signal, or spell instability. Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress. Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.
- Fear Spends: Spend Fear to expose neglected infrastructure, stress the Custodian, or make the Keystone hum at the wrong moment. Make neglected infrastructure answer at the wrong moment. Stress the Custodian's trust without turning her into a device.
- Story Scope: Perceived antagonist: the forest. True antagonist: the corporate lie about the forest. The players never confront it directly. They are meant to feel it by the end. Every act offers at least one guaranteed and one earned hint that the danger is manufactured and the forest is not the enemy. The sealed package is the capital's ward Keystone; the city is unwarded while it is away. KEEP GUARANTEED "The wood never needed managing. It needed leaving alone." ADD SEED "Your capital's safety is older than your contracts. It is the very thing they teach you to fear." ADD SEED The Keystone's magic is pre-corporate forest-ward work, the same school companies call primitive. ADD EARNED Knowledge Hard 20 The Custodian glances at obsolete Soulsfire inspection seals on her counterweight boulder. ADD EARNED Instinct Medium 15 Presence: earn candor. Knowledge: place the magic. Instinct: read the Custodian's fear. ACT4 Act 4: Hanging Office 160 2:05 to 2:40 2:40 Custodian, Keystone reveal, new objective, short rest Compress the reveal; bank the Short Rest into travel narration.
- Mechanics: The party is in Act Four pressure: The Custodian insists the Keystone must be renewed at Open Vale? Ritual Site. Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting. s04-05-carry-the-keystone-through-the-dark-path S04-05 Carry the Keystone through the dark path Carry the Keystone through the dark path Strength Agility Strength Agility 12 Strength bears weight; Agility moves safely with it. The asset becomes a burden at the worst moment. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains

Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The asset becomes a...

- Roll Cards: s04-05-carry-the-keystone-through-the-dark-path S04-05 Carry the Keystone through the dark path Carry the Keystone through the dark path Strength Agility Strength Agility 12 Strength bears weight; Agility moves safely with it. The asset becomes a burden at the worst moment. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. The asset becomes a burden at the worst moment. Use a hard complication, lost time, worse position, GM Fear, or mark Stress. Apply an official condition only if the fiction and rules justify it. The attempt falls short, but a partial thread appears. Offer one clue, weak position, or safer follow-up. The PC gets the core result...
- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.
- Search Loot Clues: No fixed loot. Offer clue, texture, or hospitality only when the fiction supports it.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: Toward Open Vale asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Agility, Instinct, Presence, Strength. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Location Ids: open-valetm-ritual-site
- Item Ids: whitefire-ward-charm
- Image Asset Status: image\_gen

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